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PUSH/PULL/LEGS EXPLAINED: THE MOST POPULAR SPLIT FOR A REASON

How push/pull/legs is structured, who it fits, and why the 6-day version beats the 3-day version for frequency.

If you've spent any time around a gym or a fitness account online, you've heard of push/pull/legs, PPL for short. It's arguably the most popular training split among lifters with real experience, and unlike a lot of trends, the popularity is earned: it solves a real problem that full-body training runs into once you're ready for more volume.

What Push/Pull/Legs Actually Is

The split organizes your training around movement direction rather than covering everything at once:

- **Push day:** chest, shoulders, and triceps, the muscles that work together on pressing movements.
- **Pull day:** back and biceps, the muscles that work together on rowing and pulling movements.
- **Leg day:** quads, hamstrings, glutes, and calves.

You can run it two ways. The 6-day version cycles through push, pull, and legs twice in a week (with a rest day worked in wherever it fits your schedule). The 3-day version runs through the same three sessions once a week, with rest days between or around them.

Why It's So Popular

Grouping muscles this way lets you dedicate an entire session's volume and energy to a small number of complementary muscle groups instead of spreading it across your whole body. That focus supports meaningfully higher volume per muscle group than full-body training allows, on a push day you can go deep on chest, shoulders, and triceps without also needing energy left over for squats and rows in the same session. For a lifter who's ready to handle more weekly volume, that's exactly the structural change that unlocks it.

Who It Fits Well

PPL is generally the right call for intermediate and advanced lifters who can commit to four to six training days a week. It's less well suited to true beginners, who don't yet need the extra volume it provides and are usually better served building movement skill on a full-body template first, and it's a poor fit for anyone who can only realistically make it to the gym two or three days a week, since a 6-day PPL rotation compressed into fewer days stops being PPL and starts being something else entirely.

The Tradeoff: Frequency Depends on How You Run It

Here's the catch, and it's the one PPL question most people never actually think through. How often each muscle group gets trained depends entirely on which version you run, and that matters a lot given the guidance covered elsewhere in this library: **most people should aim to hit each muscle group at least twice a week** for growth.

- **The 6-day version** (push, pull, legs, push, pull, legs) trains every muscle group twice in the week. This satisfies that twice-a-week frequency guidance well, and it's the version most commonly meant when people talk about "running PPL" for serious growth.
- **The 3-day version** (push, pull, legs, once each) only trains every muscle group once a week. That's the same frequency limitation as the old-school "bro split" this library's volume article specifically moved away from, if you're chasing maximum growth, a single weekly pass through push, pull, and legs may leave real progress on the table compared to hitting each muscle group twice.

Neither version is "wrong," the 3-day version is still a perfectly reasonable option for someone who genuinely only has three days and wants more per-session focus than full-body training gives. But if you have the schedule to run the full 6-day rotation, it's the version that lines up best with the frequency and volume guidance already covered in this library.

What This Means for You

- Push/pull/legs groups training by movement pattern: push (chest, shoulders, triceps), pull (back, biceps), and legs (quads, hamstrings, glutes, calves).
- It supports higher volume per muscle group than full-body training because each session focuses on fewer muscle groups.
- It fits intermediate and advanced lifters who can commit to four to six training days a week.
- The 6-day version trains each muscle group twice a week and lines up well with general frequency guidance; the 3-day version only trains each muscle group once and may fall short for someone chasing maximum growth.
- Choose the version that matches the days you actually have, not the one you think sounds more serious.

This article is educational and general in nature, not individualized medical or fitness advice. If you're new to resistance training or returning after an injury, work with a coach to learn proper form before increasing load or intensity, and talk to your doctor before starting a new training program if you have an underlying medical condition.